managed to use maritime forces to successfully defend coastal forts from the Siddis, Portuguese, English, and Dutch between 1710 and 1729. [57] The Marathas were not the only Indian rulers to operate at sea. For example, the famed British Admiral Horatio Nelson's first ever battle experience was against 'armed cruisers' from Mysore, then ruled by Hyder Ali, which the British initially mistook for 'Marratta' vessels. [58]

Another empire that played an important role in shaping India's interactions with external powers was that of the Sikhs. The Sikhs ruled a sizeable territory that extended directly or indirectly into modern-day Afghanistan and parts of Tibet. The rise of the Sikh Empire under Maharaja Ranjit Singh was itself a product of conflict with outsiders. His military successes against the Afghan Durrani dynasty briefly ensured Sikh dominance in the Punjab from Amritsar to Lahore to Peshawar. Allying with British forces, Sikh soldiers marched in Kabul in 1839. [59] Under Sikh suzerainty, the Dogras led by Gulab Singh established themselves as leaders in Jammu and after 1834 Ladakh. In 1841, in a bid to dominate the wool trade, Gulab Singh's ablest general Zorawar Singh led a force of 6000 soldiers into western Tibet. Among other things, this led to fears among British officials of an alliance between the Sikhs and Nepal. While Zorawar made initial advances, his forces were defeated near Missar in Tibet and Zorawar himself was killed. A counter-invasion by Tibetan forces into Ladakh resulted in their defeat in 1842, and a signing of a treaty that recognized Dogra rule of Ladakh but not of Tibet. [60] (This did not prevent future Dogra leaders from sometimes including Tibet in their claims.)

The political history of India is often dominated by North India with detours to the Deccan and South. But North-East India had its own extraordinary legacy, including engagement and conflict with what is today Myanmar, Southeast Asia, and Southwest China. At the centre of much of this engagement during the second millennium was the Tai Ahom dynasty based in present-day Assam. After developing a militia system that helped withstand the Mughal Empire, Ahom rule peaked in the seventeenth century before a combination of popular rebellions in the late eighteenth century, repeated Burmese invasions in the 1820s, and British intervention resulted